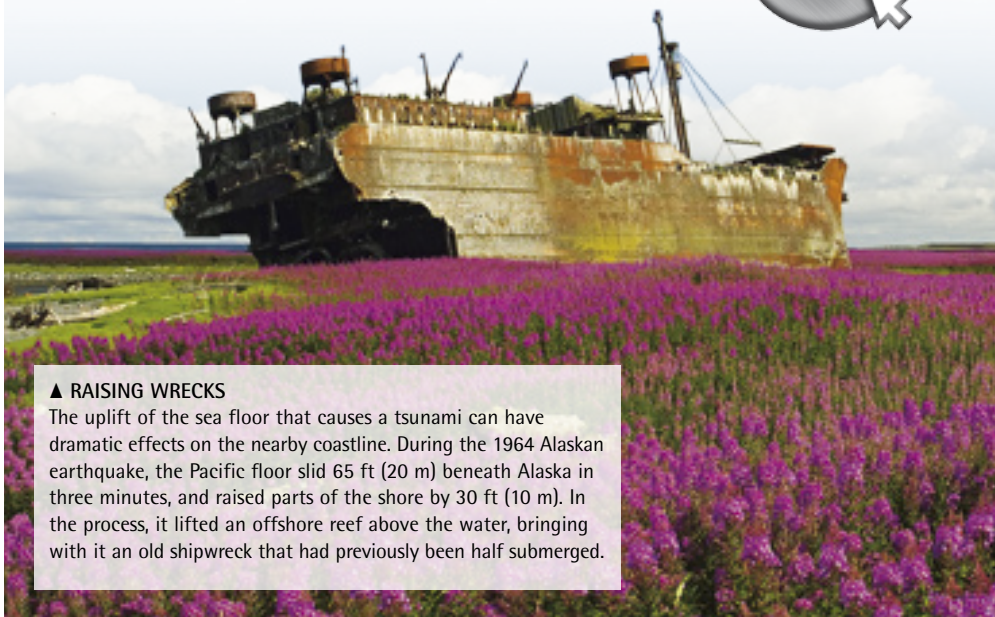
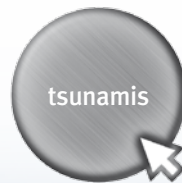




▲ CATASTROPHE

When tsunami waves reach the shore they can build up into huge mounds of water that sweep away everything in their path. This happened during the 2004 Asian tsunami when large areas of nearby Sumatra were devastated, and more than 100,000 people died in Indonesia alone. The waves had their greatest impact on human settlements, while natural habitats were less affected.



▲ RAISING WRECKS

The uplift of the sea floor that causes a tsunami can have dramatic effects on the nearby coastline. During the 1964 Alaskan earthquake, the Pacific floor slid 65 ft (20 m) beneath Alaska in three minutes, and raised parts of the shore by 30 ft (10 m). In the process, it lifted an offshore reef above the water, bringing with it an old shipwreck that had previously been half submerged.



▲ EARLY WARNING

After a tsunami hit Hawaii in 1946, an early warning system was set up in the Pacific to warn of similar disasters. It uses buoys to detect waves while they are still traveling across the open ocean and transmit the data to shore before a tsunami strikes. Unfortunately, there was no such system operating in the Indian Ocean in 2004.